

Stablecoin Credit Infrastructure for AI Agents

THESIS Businesses are delegating more commercial activity to AI agents and will increasingly fund that activity with credit rather than prefunded balances. A new category of stablecoin-based agentic lenders is being built to finance that spending, alongside the infrastructure needed to underwrite, distribute and manage that credit.

OPPORTUNITY

Businesses are beginning to delegate purchasing and other financial activity to AI agents, moving more digital spend into machine-to-machine workflows. An agent can now pay Exa for a web search or Hyperbolic for GPU inference, making thousands of purchases a day at a few cents each. Stablecoins were not built for this, but they are already widely used because they move small payments programmatically and settle quickly.

While payments solve how agents pay, credit expands how much activity those rails can support. Businesses already finance spending with cards and credit facilities. Extending that model to machine-to-machine commerce would let agents transact against approved business credit as spending occurs, with permissions, spending limits, sanctions screening and behavioral checks applied before each payment. As agent activity grows, I believe this creates a new B2B lending market, alongside the underwriting, distribution, identity and risk infrastructure needed to support it.

WHY NOW?

- 01 Machine-to-machine payments are quickly scaling.** x402, launched in May 2025, lets AI agents pay for data, API access or compute without a human checkout. Monthly volume grew 98% MoM to \$1.45M in August 2026, up ~630x YoY from ~\$2,300 in August 2025.
- 02 Stablecoins are already widely used in machine-to-machine payments.** In Q2 2026, USDC accounted for 99.3% of x402 agent-payment volume, and Circle's Agent Stack had grown to 900+ paid services.
- 03 Credit is entering agent workflows.** t54's Claw Credit and SohoPay let agents pay for APIs and compute on credit, with the business settling later. SohoPay, founded by a former American Express executive, is modeling its network on the Amex closed loop, funded by a liquidity pool.
- 04 On-chain lending already provides a large capital base.** Outstanding loans across major DeFi lending protocols reached \$26.1B in August 2026, up nearly 30% from June.
- 05 Stablecoins now have a U.S. regulatory framework.** The GENIUS Act, signed in July 2025, set federal rules for payment stablecoins.
- 06 Agent identity and permission standards are forming.** ERC-8004 (agent identity and reputation) and Coinbase's Agentic Wallets (programmable spending limits) let lenders know which agent is spending and within what bounds.

PROBLEM AND WHITESPACE

- 01 Agent payment infrastructure has developed faster than agent financing.** Businesses can give agents cards or wallets, but funding remains split between traditional credit and prefunded stablecoin balances.
- 02 Corporate cards provide credit but are poorly suited to continuous payments of cents or fractions of a cent.** Stablecoin rails fit better, but the wallet must be funded in advance. Neither combines machine-native payments with embedded credit.
- 03 Existing business credit does not connect to stablecoin workflows.** Borrowed funds must be converted, transferred and made available before an agent can spend them on-chain. Credit needs to be delivered through the same asset and workflow the agent uses.
- 04 On-chain lending provides substantial capital, but most markets are built around crypto collateral rather than underwriting operating businesses.** The capital exists, but the product connecting it to business activity is still underdeveloped.
- 05 On-chain risk and identity tools focus on wallets, transactions and agent behavior.** Business credit requires connecting that activity to the company behind the agent, its repayment capacity and the authority delegated to each agent.

KEY RISKS

- 01 Existing credit is good enough.** Focus on use cases where stablecoins materially improve payment or funding economics.
- 02 Agent spend stays too small.** Target recurring, capital-intensive categories such as compute and infrastructure.
- 03 Agent data adds little to underwriting.** Keep business-level credit analysis at the core.
- 04 Institutional funding is slow.** Build around structures that meet lender risk and compliance requirements.

WHERE COMPANIES WILL BUILD

Stablecoin-based agentic credit will create opportunities across direct lending and enabling infrastructure.

Agentic lenders

Stablecoin-native lenders will originate facilities that businesses make available directly to AI agents, so credit is drawn as spending occurs rather than prefunded. Stablecoins support small, frequent transactions while giving lenders access to both institutional and on-chain capital. t54's Claw Credit finances API and compute purchases at the transaction level, and SohoPay is building a closed-loop model where a liquidity pool funds agent payments and merchants pay for acceptance.

I expect agentic lending to expand from transaction-level credit into working-capital and receivables financing as more agent spend moves onto stablecoin rails. The winners will need underwriting and governance standards that attract institutional capital without sacrificing on-chain flexibility and liquidity.

Embedded credit platforms and marketplaces

Business lending marketplaces already aggregate fragmented credit supply rather than lend from their own balance sheets. Agentic platforms can apply the same model to stablecoin credit: dedicated marketplaces can compare facilities from agentic lenders, while wallets and agent platforms can add credit distribution to their existing customers, giving businesses one interface instead of separate lender integrations.

From conversations with several crypto companies, lending marketplaces with agent-credit features are in development but not yet announced. I expect these platforms to become the routing layer for agent credit, with the strongest positions held by those combining broad lender access with distribution inside agent workflows.

On-chain credit intelligence

Fintech lenders and private credit firms will enter stablecoin-based agentic lending but will be slow to build on-chain underwriting internally. Legacy systems, compliance constraints and regulatory uncertainty will push them toward external providers, just as institutions already rely on Chainalysis and TRM Labs to interpret on-chain activity.

Blockchain analytics firms will naturally extend into credit, and new platforms are emerging, though focused on wallet and transaction data. Cred Protocol provides on-chain scoring and reporting for AI agents, while Agentic's credit scores autonomous trading agents on verifiable wallet performance and distributes those scores through APIs. As agentic lending grows, these providers will become an external risk layer for new lenders.

Identity, permissions and privacy

Confidentiality already constrains institutional activity on public blockchains, driving adoption of privacy-enabled networks such as Canton. Agentic lending adds another requirement: lenders must verify which business controls an agent and what authority it has been delegated.

zkMe and Privado ID are developing credentials that prove identity and permissions without publishing the underlying data on-chain. I expect this to become a required layer for institutional agentic lending, with the strongest providers offering credentials reusable across lenders while preserving the commercial privacy businesses expect.